# Forge Viral Discovery Checkpoint — 2026-05-11 — AXEL

## Status: pending_review

## Recommended Path (Algorithmic)

**Step 1 (now):** Build **AXEL: ZERO** as 1–2 week web prototype. Validate cascade-clip K-factor + audience. **Step 2 (week 2–3):** If ZERO K > 0.5 → start **AXEL: Resonance** as 3–4 week Steam release. **Step 3 (week 6–8):** Launch AXEL: Resonance on Steam during sub-genre's still-rising window.

## Your Review Selections

### For Prompt Generation (Solo Build):

- ☐ VAR-005: AXEL: ZERO (validation prototype)
- ☐ VAR-002: AXEL: Resonance (full release)
- ☐ VAR-004: AXEL: Tilt (narrative alternative)

### For Team Discussion (if friend has pixel artist):

- ☐ VAR-001: AXEL: Grease (CloverPit-zeitgeist aesthetic — needs artist)

### Parked / Skipped:

- ☑ VAR-003: AXEL: Sigil (crowded fantasy lane, recommend skip)

## Notes / Domain Knowledge

Friend's existing AXEL spec already locks in cascade-cluster mechanics + run progression + area-themed items + sub-casino RTP. This discovery validates that direction is **on-trend and unoccupied at the exact mechanic** (cascading-cluster slot in roguelite frame).

The Moon Princess 100 visual/naming IP needs full reframe — see `03-reframing.md`. Mechanics are fully safe.

**Critical timing:** CloverPit shipped 100k copies in a day. Sub-genre is in active growth. Build window ~6–12 weeks before competitors crowd the cascading-cluster angle specifically.

## Open Questions for Friend

1. Pixel artist access? (decides whether AXEL: Grease is on the table)
2. Web prototype first (AXEL: ZERO) or skip straight to Steam release?
3. Cosmic (Resonance) vs heist (Tilt) for the full release theme?
4. Target platform priority: Steam-first, mobile-first, or web-first?